MARVEL

1

EWING
PAKNADEL
VAUGHAN
FERREYRA
NOWLAN

THE IMMORTAL HULK

TIME OF MONSTERS

“I BEHOLD THEE ENKIDU; LIKE A GOD THOU ART.
WHY WITH THE ANIMALS
WANDEREST THOU ON THE PLAIN?”

– *THE EPIC OF GILGAMESH*,
TRANSLATED BY STEPHEN HERBERT LANGDON

JORDAN,
9,500 BCE.

YOU'RE YOUNG, TAMMUZ. YOU WON'T REMEMBER WHEN THE MOTHER GODDESS STILL WATCHED OVER US WITH HER *GOOD GREEN EYE.*

WE THOUGHT IT A BLESSING AT FIRST, BUT WE WERE A *PUNY* PEOPLE THEN--PUNY AND *PROUD.* WE TOOK TALL RYE AND SWEET MILK FOR OUR BIRTHRIGHT.

BUT THE MOTHER GODDESS IS A *TEACHER* ABOVE ALL, SO SHE PUT OUT HER EYE AND CAST IT *HERE,* THE BETTER TO MARK THE SQUANDERING OF HER GIFTS.

THE GROUND SHOOK. THE SKY WAS A PILLAR OF ASH AND GREEN FLAME. WE DANCED AND WEPT FOR JOY.

BUT SOON ALL THAT FELL BENEATH THE GAZE OF THE MOTHER GODDESS' GOOD GREEN EYE BECAME *ROTTED.*

EVERY GRAIN. EVERY GAZELLE. EVERY PEST AND CUR.

ALL WITHERED.

YOU CAN FEEL IT HERE, CAN'T YOU...?

MAGIC SO STRONG IT *STINGS THE EYES.*

ADAD-- *HONORED ELDER-- PLEASE.*

LISTEN. SUCH MAGIC CAN BE RECKONED WITH NEITHER EASILY NOR CHEAPLY.

OUR LANDS BLACKENED LIKE A DEAD TOOTH.

KNOWING NO BETTER, OUR CHILDREN BECAME *RESTLESS.*

THEIR FAITH-- *YOUR* FAITH-- FALTERED.

MY SON LOVES YOU AS A *BROTHER,* TAMMUZ. HE WOULD FOLLOW YOU ANYWHERE.

THAT IS WHY I CANNOT ALLOW YOU TO *LEAVE.*

I KNOW WHAT YOU SAY ABOUT ME BEHIND MY BACK, BOY...

THAT MY WITS HAVE FLED. THAT I AM LEADING OUR VILLAGE TO RUIN.

BUT I KNOW WHAT THE EYE *WANTS.*

ALL THOSE SUMMERS OF FLASHING SICKLES AND EASY GAME.

WE TOOK... *ENDLESSLY.*

SOMETHING IN MY CHEST... *BROKEN.*

BUT WE DID NOT *GIVE.*

WE ARE *STARVING*, ADAD.

EVEN THE WILD HERDS HAVE ABANDONED US. THEY CAN TASTE THE *DEATH* IN OUR WATER.

WAIT... WHY ARE WE HERE?

WHY HAVE YOU BROUGHT ME BEFORE THE *EYE?*

THE ANCESTORS SPOKE TO ME.

THEY SAID THE GENTLE SEASONS WILL RETURN. IT CAN *ALL* BE PUT BACK TOGETHER.

BUT NOT WHILE THE HEAVENS ARE HALF-BLIND.

NO!

NYAARGH!!!

THERE IS NO GREAT REMEDY WITHOUT GREAT SACRIFICE, TAMMUZ!

I WILL TELL *SHALIM* YOU WERE UNAFRAID!

BUT... BUT LEAVING WASN'T...

MY IDEA.

BUT IT'S TOO LATE.

TAMMUZ FEELS THE GOOD GREEN EYE'S GAZE AND HE IS *OVERTHROWN.*

THERE'S A HISSING IN HIS EARS LIKE RAIN ON HOT STONES, AND HE WISHES IT WOULD STOP.

PRICKLING ON THE TONGUE. BUZZING IN THE BONES. A WHIRL OF NOVEL SENSATIONS.

HE WILL HAVE QUITE THE STORY TO TELL SHALIM ONCE THEY HAVE THE VILLAGE AT THEIR BACKS.

BUT PERHAPS IT IS TOO LATE TO LEAVE TODAY.

BESIDES, FIRST HE NEEDS TO BE WARM. IT IS SO VERY COLD OUT HERE WITHOUT SKINS ON ONE'S SHOULDERS.

AS HIS VISION CLOUDS, HE SEES A DOOR--A *HEAVY GREEN DOOR*, KINDLY AS A GRANDMOTHER...

...AND SOMEONE IS LOOKING THROUGH IT.

"I KNOW, MOTHER. HE'S *LATE.*"

WHEEEEEN?

WE WERE SUPPOSED TO FLEE THIS PLACE AND ITS SOUR MAGIC AT FIRST LIGHT, BUT YOU KNOW TAMMUZ; HE *DITHERS.*

PLEASE WATCH OVER HIM, MOTHER.

I HAVE A *FEELING...*

SHALIM?

TTT! STILL PECKING AT YOUR MOTHER'S BONES, I SEE. YOU SHOULD LET HER REST.

FATHER! EVERYONE WAS LOOKING FOR YOU.

YOU'RE PACKED.

FOR A LONG JOURNEY, FROM THE LOOKS OF THINGS.

UH... TAMMUZ AND I WERE GOING TO FORAGE FOR DATES NEAR THE ***SHELL PEOPLE'S*** VILLAGE.

THE PALMS ARE STILL GOOD THERE.

AUROCHS MEAT AND BARLEY BREAD.

WERE YOU PLANNING TO BE GONE UNTIL THE ***NEXT NEW MOON?***

...

FATHER, HAVE YOU SEEN TAMMUZ?

NO.

WHY DO YOU ASK?

YOU ALREADY ***KNOW,*** DON'T YOU?

WHAT DID YOU DO TO HIM?

WHAT DID YOU ***DO*** TO HIM, YOU WORM-ADDLED OLD JACKAL?!

I'VE SAVED US ALL, BOY!

KRAK!

ADAD! ADAD!

LOOK AT ME, *MILKSOP!*

HKKK!!!

TAMMUZ DIDN'T MAKE A SOUND WHEN THE EYE ATE OF HIS FLESH. NOT A SOUND!

HE UNDERSTOOD WHAT CIVILIZATION *IS*, SHALIM--WHAT IT *COSTS!*

HONORED ELDER--

LEAVE US!

THERE'S A BEAST IN THE GORGE! *ENORMOUS!* ENOUGH TO FEED *US ALL* FOR...

PLEASE, YOU *MUST* COME!

IT WORKED. THANK YOU, ANCESTORS.

COME, SHALIM. BRING YOUR BOW.

"YOU HAVE A CHANCE TO *REDEEM* YOURSELF YET."

TAMMUZ DOESN'T REMEMBER HOW HE GOT HERE. (WAS ADAD WITH HIM?) BUT IT HARDLY MATTERS NOW.

HE KNOWS HE SHOULD FIND SHALIM. HE KNOWS HE SHOULD *STICK TO THE PLAN.*

BUT HIS MIND IS *DANCING WITH FOXFIRE.* SO MANY *IDEAS.* SO MANY WAYS HE CAN *HELP.*

THE RAIN IS *POISON,* SO HE SHOULD REALLY START *THERE.*

STREAMS. THERE ARE STREAMS *UNDERGROUND. CLEAN. PURE.* WITH THE RIGHT TOOLS, THEY CAN BE TAPPED.

THE GLEAMING ROCK IS KEY. HE WILL CRUSH IT. HE WILL *SMASH* IT.

WITH FIRE HE WILL MELT THE GLEAM LIKE TALLOW AND SHAPE IT CUNNINGLY.

THE FIRE WILL MAKE THE TOOLS. THE TOOLS WILL MAKE *THE FUTURE.*

AND OF COURSE, THERE'S THE *POWER.* *TORRENTS* OF IT. ENOUGH TO *BREAK WORLDS.*

BUT LIKE THE *STREAMS UNDERGROUND* THAT FLOW WITHOUT SURCEASE, IT IS TOO CLEAN AND TOO PURE TO BE DANGEROUS.

HE WILL SHARE THIS POWER WITH HIS VILLAGE-- WITH *ALL* THE VILLAGES. FROM THE SHELL PEOPLE OF THE WEST TO THE BONE TALKERS OF THE EAST.

HE WILL CARRY THEM *ALL* INTO TOMORROW-- *ON HIS BACK* IF NEED BE.

THEY NEED A *LEADER.* IF ONLY FOR A LITTLE WHILE.

SHALIM WILL WAIT FOR HIM. SHALIM WILL UNDERST--

NO.

HEAVE!

NO!

GRANDFATHERS... *LOOK* AT IT.

PAIN! NOISE!

SHLUK!

WHY ARE THEY DOING THIS?!

HE HAS BROUGHT *GIFTS!* HE *IS* A GIFT!

SKLICH!

SKLICH!

SKLICH!

ENOUGH!

TAMMUZ IS CHANGED, BUT THESE ARE STILL *HIS PEOPLE.* HE NEED ONLY EXPLAIN, AND ALL WILL BE WELL.

GLK! HRAAAGGH!!!

HE TRIES TO WREST WORDS FROM HIS LUNGS, BUT HIS THROAT GRINDS THEM INTO CHAFF.

KRA-KOOM

THEN THERE IS A SOFT WHICKERING ON THE WIND, AND HE KNOWS ALL IS LOST.

THUNNNK!!!

THE DOOR IS LIGHTER THIS TIME.

PERHAPS YOU'RE NOT SUCH A MILKSOP AFTER ALL, EH, SHALIM?

...

THAT BIRTHMARK...

TAMMUZ?

WH... WHERE AM I?

NO.

THERE WAS *ANOTHER.*

YOU BEAR MY MARK

THEY HAVE ALL TURNED THEIRS FROM ME. EVEN SHALIM.

I WOULD HAVE GIVEN THEM *EVERYTHING.*

I TURN MY FACE TOWARD YOU

I AM THE ONE BELOW ALL

WITH THESE HANDS I BREAK
WITH THIS MOUTH I HOWL

BREAK. YES, I THINK I WOULD LIKE TO BREAK THINGS NOW.

I WOULD LIKE THAT VERY MUCH.

MY WEAPON IS HATE

GOOD.

AS IS MINE.

ITS *LIVER*, SHALIM! LOOK AT IT!

YOU EARNED IT. EAT YOUR FILL.

...

LATER, PERHAPS.

FRIENDS!

LOOK AT US!

BELLIES FULL OF MEAT...

GREASE DRIPPING DOWN OUR CHINS...

ALL IS AS IT SHOULD BE.

ALMOST.

FIRST, LET US HAIL THE TRUE AIM OF MY SON, SHALIM!

THE POOR CREATURE WAS FRANTIC WITH PAIN, AND HE SHOWED IT A *HUNTER'S MERCY.*

BUT WHILE OUR SPEARS AND ARROWS FELLED THE BRUTE, THEY DID NOT SUMMON IT.

IT WAS THE MOTHER GODDESS' GIFT!

BY NOW YOU WILL ALL HAVE REALIZED THAT SOMEONE IS MISSING FROM THIS FEAST...

TAMMUZ. DEAR TAMMUZ.

MY SISTER TOOK HIM IN WHEN THE FEVER TOOK HIS MOTHER. HE WAS FAMILY.

TODAY HE OFFERED HIMSELF WILLINGLY TO THE MOTHER GODDESS' GOOD GREEN EYE.

I KNOW THIS BECAUSE I WAS WITH HIM AT THE END.

SHLORP

HE BEGGED ME TO TELL YOU NOT TO MOURN HIM.

"HE CROSSED OVER WITH A SMILING HEART BECAUSE HE KNEW HIS PEOPLE'S FUTURE WAS ASSURED."

THERE HAS BEEN SOME *TALK*--ESPECIALLY AMONG THE *YOUNG*--OF ABANDONING OUR LANDS...

OF FORAGING IN THE WETLANDS LIKE OUR HALF-WILD ANCESTORS.

BUT LOOK! THIS *MEAT* IS A BOON FROM THE MOTHER GODDESS HERSELF!

IT IS PROOF THAT WE CAN *KEEP FAITH* WITH OUR WAYS AND *STILL* HAVE ALL WE NEED!

TAMMUZ HAS SHOWN US THE *PRICE* THE EYE DEMANDS. IT IS THE PRICE OF *CIVILIZATION.*

BUT *WE NEED NOT PAY IT OURSELVES!*

TOMORROW I WILL TAKE A HUNTING PARTY TO THE VILLAGE OF THE *BONE TALKERS.*

FATHER...

WE WILL--NN!--SURPRISE THEM. WE WILL *SUBDUE* THEM, AND WE WILL OFFER *THEM* UP TO THE *GOOD GREEN EYE.*

AND WE WILL BE MADE *WHOLE.*

A-DAD! A-DAD! A-DAD!

FATHER, ITS *EYE!*

WAIT. I FEEL... GLLKKK!!!

THE FIRE GUTTERS.

ADAD, WHAT IS-- HALCCHH!!!

THE CHEERING STOPS.

THERE IS RIPPING. THERE IS PAIN. THE FEAST IS *OVER.*

GOOD. PERHAPS NOW THEY WILL *UNDERSTAND.*

THE GREEN DOOR OPENS LIKE A FLOWER.

NO!

HE IS *RETURNED.*

WITH A THOUGHT, HE SUMMONS HIMSELF TO HIMSELF...AND *SMILES.*

THE POWER FEELS DIFFERENT THIS TIME. IT IS NOT MEANT FOR *BUILDING.*

HIS GOOD GREEN EYE WIDENS, DRINKING IN EVERY DELECTABLE TWITCH AND SHUDDER OF HIS MURDERERS' BODIES...

...UNTIL ONLY ONE REMAINS.

I...I DIDN'T KNOW, TAMMUZ! I *SWEAR!*

TAMMUZ KNOWS HE COULD SPEAK NOW IF HE WISHED-- SHAPE THE ROCKSLIDE IN HIS CHEST INTO WORDS.

SPEAK THE ***WHY*** OF IT. TEACH THE ***LESSON*** OF IT.

HE COULD STILL LEAVE WITH SHALIM AS THEY PLANNED. EVEN NOW--EVEN AFTER THE ***SCREAMS*** AND THE ***RENDING***-- IT MIGHT NOT BE TOO LATE.

THEY COULD STILL FIND THAT BETTER PLACE IN HIS MIND.

HE COULD STOP.

HE COULD STOP MAKING THEM PAY.

IF HE WISHED.

SHLKK

BUT THERE IS A VOICE OF GREEN FIRE IN HIS HEAD, FROM A PLACE BELOW ALL PLACES.

A VOICE THAT SAYS "NEVER."

AND WHEN TAMMUZ FINALLY LEAVES THE VILLAGE...

...HE LEAVES ALONE.

TIME OF MONSTERS

ALEX PAKNADEL & AL EWING STORY ALEX PAKNADEL SCRIPT JUAN FERREYRA ART & COVER VC'S CORY PETIT LETTERER

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HULK CREATED BY STAN LEE & JACK KIRBY

WELCOME TO VERDIGRIS K·A·N·S·A·S POPULATION: ~~20~~ 5931

VERD

JACKSON

EMERALD

EMERALD

ONE PLEASE.

WELCOME TO THE EMERALD CINEMA, DR. BANNER.

THE SHOW'S ABOUT TO START.

IS THIS RIGHT? I WAS JUST PASSING THROUGH...

BUT I REMEMBER REPORTS OF MISSING PEOPLE...

WHY, THEY'RE ALL HERE!

NOTHING PACKS THE HOUSE LIKE MASS HYPNOSIS.

IT'S THE HOTTEST TICKET IN TOWN, BUT DON'T WORRY...

EXIT

EXIT

...I SAVED YOU A SEAT.

SEE BRUCE, THE FOLKS IN THIS DYING, PODUNK TOWN WERE AFRAID.

AFRAID OF OPIOIDS, FLOODS, FORECLOSURES. CLOWNS.

IT'S ALWAYS CLOWNS.

I FEED ON FEAR, AND THIS OLD THEATER GAVE ME AN IDEA.

DINNER AND A SHOW! DOT HERE IS *BOTH.*

DOTTIE

SHE WATCHES HER WORST NIGHTMARE ON SCREEN WHILE I EAT HER ASTRAPHOBIA-- FEAR OF STORMS.

AS PSYCHIC CONCESSIONS GO, SHE'S JUST A SNACK.

BUT YOU, BRUCE BANNER...

YOU'RE MY BIG OL' BUCKET OF POPCORN.

DON'T... HURT HER.

GET... OUT OF MY HEAD...

AH-AH! NO CHANGING!

THIS SEAT IS RESERVED FOR YOU ALONE.

SEE THE FUTURE YOU FEAR!

NO!

NOT THAT.

NOT THAT!

OH, LOOK AT IT ALL! EXISTENTIAL THREATS...

WORLD-BREAKERS... THE END OF EVERYTHING!

AHHHH!

MAKE IT STOP!

NEVER! MORE!

I'M...

...SORRY...

uhkk...

WHOOPS. KILLED ANOTHER ONE. I ALWAYS OVERDO IT.

WELL, I'M STUFFED.

HA!

BUT MAYBE SOME DESSERT.

OH DOTTIE... MY LITTLE MILK DUD...

SCARED TO DEATH.

THAT WAS PUNY EVEN FOR BANNER.

RRRRRIIIPPPPP

WHAT?

NO.

IT'S IMPOSSIBLE!

DON'T YOU LOVE A GOOD TWIST?

THE SCARECROW. STARK USED TO WHINE ABOUT YOU.

FREAKY PHEROMONES AND MIND CONTROL.

ASTRAL "PROJECTION." CUTE TRICK.

THAT STUFF WON'T WORK ON ME.

AND TERAPHOBIA WON'T WORK ON ME.

I'M NOT SCARED OF MONSTERS.

NO...

...BUT THEY ARE.

RUN! MOVE! HE'S RIGHT BEHIND US!!!

EXIT

DOTTIE

GET BACK HERE! COWARDS!

UNH! I-- HEY!

BLIMP

FINE.

YOU THINK YOU'RE A MATCH FOR ME, HULK?

WITH ALL THE FEAR-FORCE I TOOK FROM BANNER?

IN THE EMERALD CINEMA...

SCARECROW IS KING!

AAIIEEE!

CRAK

AFRAID NOT.

A SCARECROW SHOULD HAVE THE BRAINS NOT TO MESS WITH SOMEONE...

WHAM

... GREEN-SKINNED AND WICKED.

SO MUCH FOR YOUR "KINGDOM."

WAIT...

...JUST WAIT...

...ON THE SCREEN...

WHAT IS THAT?

LOOKS LIKE A MONSTER MOVIE.

THE ONLY FEAR LEFT TO PROJECT.

YOURS.

NO NO NO!

TURN IT OFF! TURN IT OFF!

VENGEFUL VILLAGERS AREN'T REALLY YOUR GREATEST FEAR, ARE THEY?

DON'T DO THIS...

PROJECTION ROOM

YOU'RE TERRIFIED TO SEE WHERE YOU END UP WHEN YOUR MOVIE'S OVER.

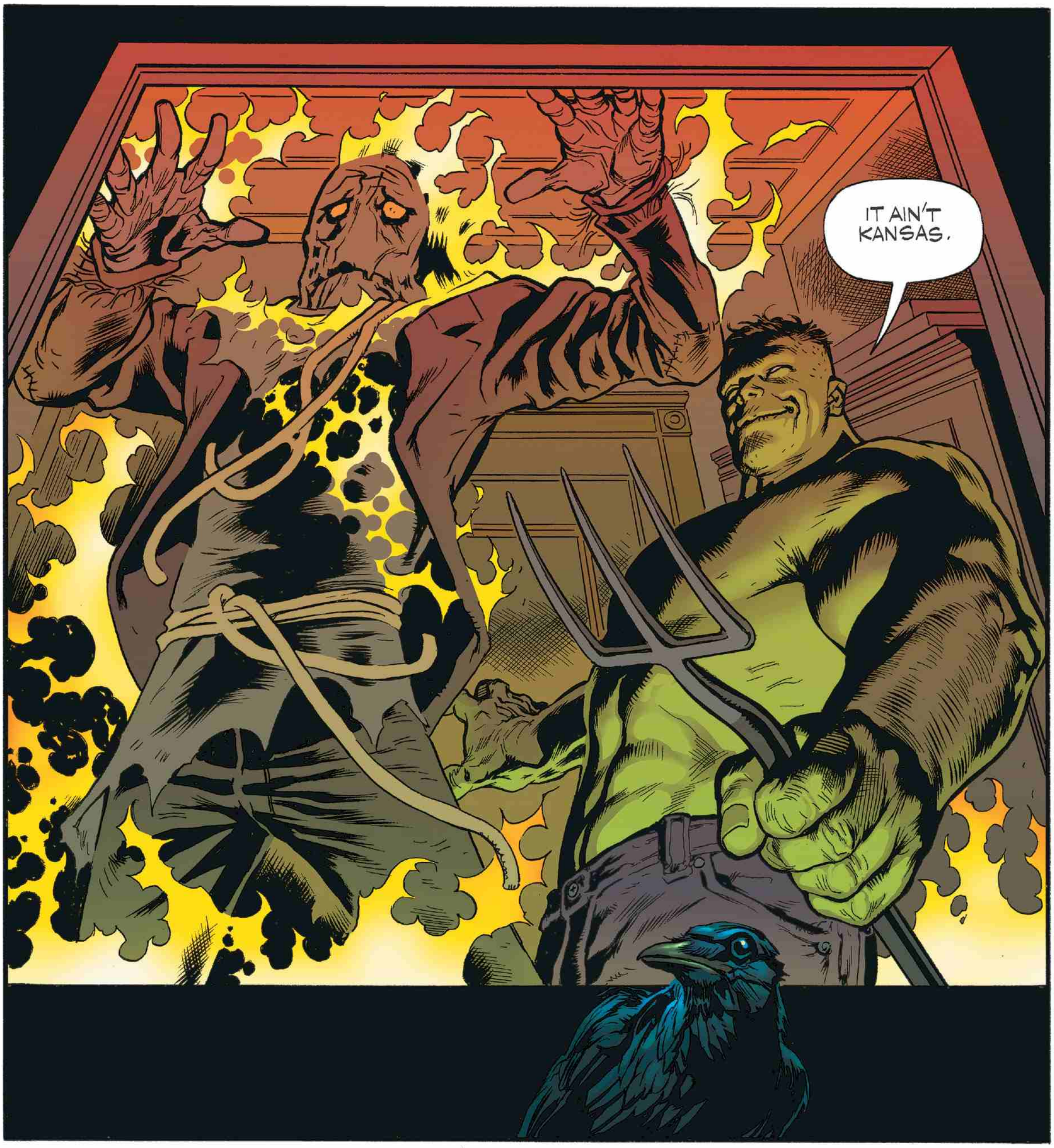
I WANT TO GO HOME...

I WANT TO GO HOME...

COME ON. LET'S TAKE A SNEAK PEEK.

A PREVIEW OF WHERE YOU'RE HEADED.

SPOILER ALERT...



A Little Fire

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GAMMA-GRAMS

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YOU KNOW WHAT TO DO, HULK-HEADS — GET THE NEXT ISSUE OF *IMMORTAL HULK* IN TWO WEEKS!

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GREEN GIANT



LIKE IT?
BUY IT!